Even as a clear explanation remained elusive, I levelled with the members of the TAC in one of the meetings to tell them that we respected their advice and that the TAC discussion added enormous value to our final judgement. I pointed out that during the entire tightening cycle, the TAC advice was never unanimous, suggesting that my decision was always finely poised. If I agreed with the minority view, it was just incidental.

The external members of the TAC are typically big names with impressive track records in the academia and economic policy. Some of them are respected columnists; and even others used to write or comment in the media sporadically. Unsurprisingly, their views would often address monetary policy issues. Both their pre- and post-policy commentary had potential market ramifications. The pre-policy view would be seen, quite logically, as the advice the member would give in the TAC, thereby setting off speculation on how it might influence the governor's decision. Similarly, any criticism by them of the policy after the release risked being misinterpreted as a note of dissent. On occasion, this became quite contentious. But we also believed that forcing an obligation of total silence on the TAC members would be unfair and unwarranted since their expression of views decidedly added value to the public discourse. To resolve this, in consultation with the TAC, we imposed a code of conduct for the external members—a voluntary 'shut period', beginning two weeks before the policy and ending a day after the policy, during which time they would not express any opinion in the media on monetary policy issues.

I made it a standard practice to follow up the full TAC meeting with a meeting with all the deputy governors. They too were members of the TAC and I believed it was only fair that I sought their views as explicitly as I did with the external members. There was seldom consensus even within this smaller, internal group; in fact, I can't recall even a single occasion when we were all agreed on a single policy mix.

You should have got the big picture by now. Opinion and advice from the wider world of analysts is all over the map, and neither the TAC nor even the core insider group of the TAC, produces a consensus. It is in this